



How Workplace Mistreatment Undermines Next-Day Work Meaningfulness : The Role of Emotional Exhaustion and Person-Level Job Burnout



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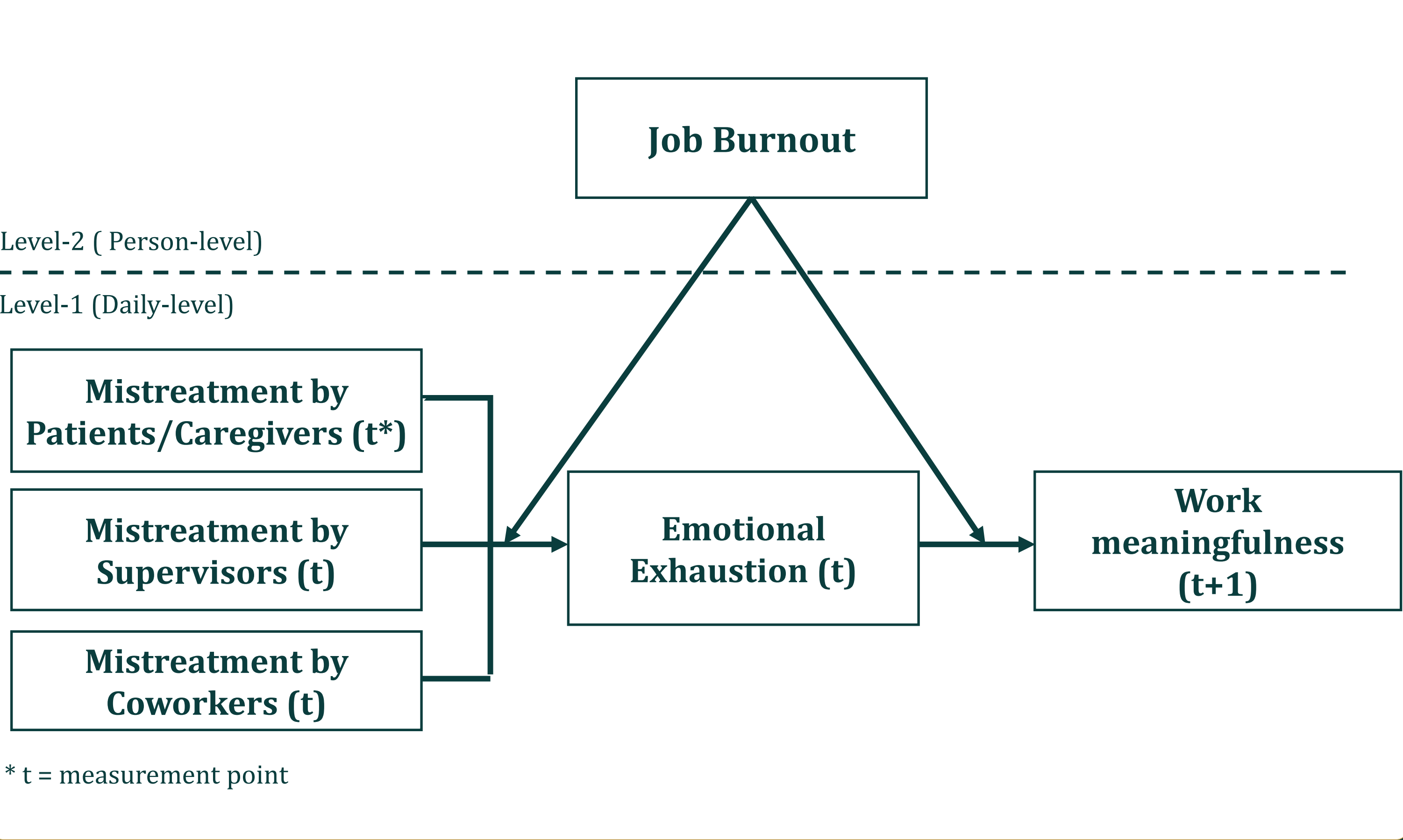


“Daily work meaningfulness is actively constructed through the *investment of psychological resources*, and is therefore *vulnerable to experiences that deplete* them.

01 BACKGROUND & HYPOTHESES

- Work meaningfulness — a central component of eudaimonic well-being — is not given but actively constructed through meaning-making, the ongoing investment of psychological resources.
- Workplace experiences that deplete these resources therefore reduce the daily capacity to sustain it.
- Workplace mistreatment is a prevalent interpersonal stressor that depletes such resources, leading to emotional exhaustion.
- Emotional exhaustion serves as a mediating mechanism linking mistreatment to lower work meaningfulness (JD-R theory).
- Person-level job burnout moderates this mediation: the negative indirect effect is amplified among chronically depleted individuals (COR theory).

02 CONCEPTUAL MODEL



03 METHOD

Participants

- 268 Korean registered nurses
- Female: 90%
- Age: $M = 31.4$ yrs ($SD = 5.6$)
- Nursing exp.: $M = 7.7$ yrs ($SD = 5.5$)
- Rotating three-shifts: 75%
- Non-managerial positions: 80%

Procedures

- Daily diary design (experience sampling method)
- Two surveys per day for 4 weeks
- After-work survey
- Before-work survey
- 3,917 matched daily observations
- $M = 14.6$ days per person (range = 3-25)

Measures

- Baseline survey
- Person-level job burnout (20-items)
- Daily after-work survey
- Workplace mistreatment:
 - Patients/Caregivers (4-items)
 - Supervisors (3-items)
 - Coworkers (3-items)
- Emotional exhaustion (3-items)
- Daily before-work survey
- Work meaningfulness (3-items)

Analysis

- Multilevel structural equation modeling using Mplus 8.9
- Bayesian estimation via MCMC

04 RESULTS

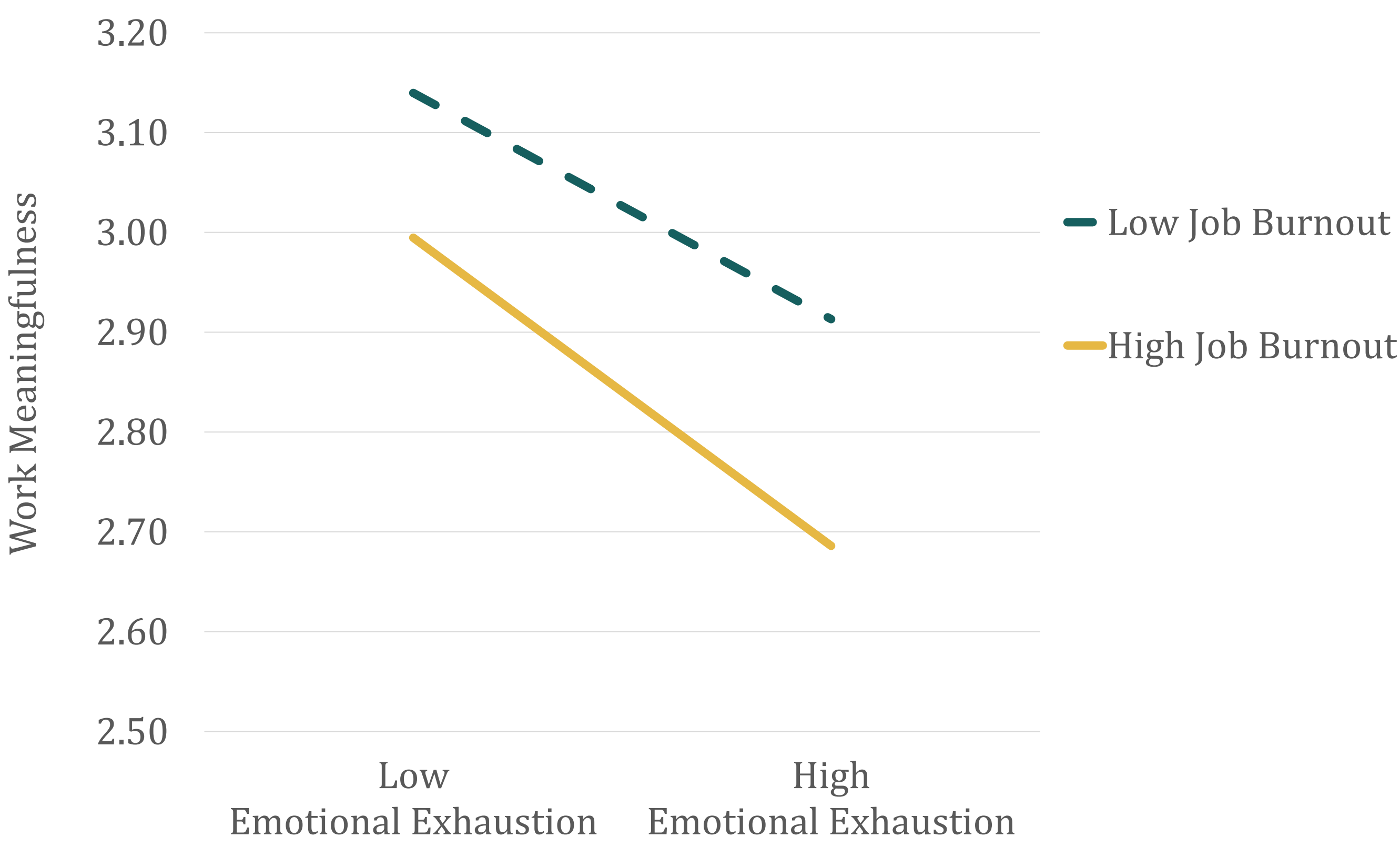
- Daily workplace mistreatment from all three sources increased emotional exhaustion, in turn reducing next-day work meaningfulness.

Indirect Effects: Mistreatment → Emotional Exhaustion → Work Meaningfulness	Estimate	Posterior SD	95% CI
Mistreatment by patients/caregivers (Mediation 1)	-0.013***	0.003	[-0.019, -0.007]
Mistreatment by supervisors (Mediation 2)	-0.015***	0.003	[-0.024, -0.008]
Mistreatment by coworkers (Mediation 3)	-0.014***	0.004	[-0.023, -0.007]

- Person-level job burnout moderated this indirect effect at the second stage (exhaustion → meaningfulness) but not the first (mistreatment → exhaustion)
- The conditional indirect effects held only for high-burnout employees.

Conditional Indirect Effects by Person-Level Job Burnout	Estimate	Posterior SD	95% CI
Moderated mediation 1 (Low)_IND1L	-0.007	0.004	[-0.016, 0.001]
Moderated mediation 2 (Low)_IND2L	-0.007	0.004	[-0.018, 0.001]
Moderated mediation 3 (Low)_IND3L	-0.005	0.004	[-0.015, 0.001]
Moderated mediation 1 (High)_IND1H	-0.017***	0.004	[-0.026, -0.009]
Moderated mediation 2 (High)_IND2H	-0.024***	0.007	[-0.039, -0.012]
Moderated mediation 3 (High)_IND3H	-0.026***	0.009	[-0.045, -0.011]

Fig1. Daily Emotional Exhaustion X Person-Level Job Burnout on Daily Work Meaningfulness



05 DISCUSSION

01. Daily interpersonal stressors as an antecedents of work meaningfulness

- Work meaningfulness is not a static attribute of job, but an experience that employees actively construct in the daily work life.
- Our findings identify daily workplace mistreatment as an antecedents of work meaningfulness.
- In doing so, we shift theoretical attention from what employees stably bring to or find in their jobs toward what they encounter day-to-day.

02. Resource-based pathway linking mistreatment to work meaningfulness

- Empirical evidence for resource-dependent nature of work meaningfulness has been scarce.
- We provide such evidence: When mistreatment deplete employees' psychological resources, their capacity to invest those resources in meaning construction is diminished.
- Our findings extend the health impairment process from hedonic and health outcomes to eudaimonic outcomes.

03. Person-level burnout amplifies the second stage, not the first

- Heightened vulnerability of depleted individuals to additional resource loss does not appear to operate by amplifying acute (first-stage) loss itself.
- Rather, this vulnerability may reflect a diminished capacity to invest remaining resources in constructing eudaimonic well-being such as work meaningfulness.